



Ken Stevens, Sr.
Fire Chief

STANDARD OPERATING PROCEDURE

TITLE:	ARSON AND BOMB, HANDLING CLANDESTINE DRUG LABORATORIES
NUMBER:	S 7812 R2
EFFECTIVE:	JUNE 18, 2018
REPLACES:	S7401 R1 (04.04.12) (formerly Bureau of Fire Prevention)
ACCOUNTABILITY:	ARSON AND BOMB
REVIEW CYCLE:	ANNUAL

Purpose:

To establish procedures and responsibilities at incidents involving suspected or confirmed clandestine drug labs.

General Information:

I. Clandestine Laboratory/Drug Lab:

- A. Operation consisting of a sufficient combination of equipment and chemicals that either have been or could be used during the illicit/illegal manufacture and/or synthesis of a controlled substance.
- B. Found anywhere ranging in size from portable labs to elaborate fixed sites.
- C. Indicators:
 - 1. Unusual odors (e.g., ether, vinegar, acetic acid, urea/urine, ammonia, rotting garbage, solvent-like odors, etc.).
 - 2. Covered or obscured windows.
 - 3. Glassware that seems out of place for the occupancy (e.g., flasks, funnels, beakers with vacuum ports, condensing towers, etc.).
 - 4. Unusual equipment (e.g., vacuum pumps, heating elements, hot plates\mantels, plastic or rubber tubing, etc.).
 - 5. Marked or unmarked chemical containers, drums, and/or gas cylinders.
- D. Common Hazards:
 - 1. Flammable, toxic, and/or explosive atmospheres.
 - 2. Water reactive, pyrophoric, and shock sensitive chemicals.
 - 3. Leaking or damaged chemical containers/compressed gas cylinders.
 - 4. Electrical hazards and sources of ignition.
 - 5. Chemical reactions
 - 6. Booby traps and/or explosive devices.
- E. Precautions:
 - 1. Do not alter the scene (e.g., move/touch any items, open/close doors or windows, turn equipment off/on, etc.).

Note: Natural gas supply to water heaters, stoves, etc. should be shut off at the exterior meter.

2. Be alert for booby traps and/or guard dogs.

F. Should be considered both a crime scene and a Hazmat incident requiring law enforcement notification and a Hazmat response.

Instructions/Procedures:

I. Response – No Fire Involvement:

A. During routine duties fire personnel may discover activity consistent with a clandestine drug laboratory.

1. Fire personnel shall:

- a. Remain alert to common hazards of drug labs.
- b. Exit to a safe area (retrace steps to the outside).
- c. Secure the scene.
- d. Request Battalion Chief and Squad 2.
- e. Request Fire Alarm Office (FAO) notify Fort Worth Police Department (FWPD).

Note: Use discretion with radio communications.

- f. Initiate gross decontamination if necessary.
- g. Initiate Hazmat procedures (set up initial Hot Zone).

2. FAO shall contact:

- a. Battalion Chief, Squad 2, and FWPD.
- b. EMS-99 (if personnel exposed).
- c. Marshal-99 if explosives/booby traps are suspected.
- d. Office of Environmental Management (OEM).

3. Battalion Chief shall ensure:

- a. Appropriate precautions.
- b. Initiation of appropriate level Hazmat response.

4. Squad 2 shall:

- a. Use appropriate instrumentation to monitor the environment.
- b. Provide support for other agencies (e.g., FWPD, OEM, etc.).

II. Response – Fire Involvement:

A. The recognition of a clandestine drug lab that is involved in fire may not be evident until fire control has been achieved. Fire personnel should be aware of the following indicators:

1. Unusual flame and/or smoke color.
2. Violent reactions when water is applied.
3. Class A Foam has little or no effect on fire intensity.
4. Explosions and/or unexplained rapid fire growth.
5. Strong chemical odors
6. Marked or unmarked containers.
7. Unusual equipment found at the involved occupancy.

B. Fire Companies shall:

1. Wear full PPE and SCBA.

2. Evacuate and notify the IC if a clandestine drug lab is suspected.
3. Initiate emergency gross decontamination procedures.

C. IC shall:

1. Consider defensive tactics or choose a fire attack plan that lessens exposure to personnel, civilians, and the environment (contain fire while protecting exposures).
2. Request FAO make notifications to:
 - a. Squad 2
 - b. TACMED (assist with exposure documentation)
 - c. M-99
 - d. FWPD
 - e. OEM
3. Initiate the appropriate level Hazmat response.
4. Ensure that initial protective zones are established.
5. Ensure respiratory safety of personnel.
6. Delay salvage and overhaul operations.

III. Other Considerations:

- A. Avoid exposure to smoke and/or spilled chemicals.
- B. Ensure proper decontamination of personnel and equipment.

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